App Inventor for Android (often abbreviated to AIA) lets you create mobile applications for the Android platform in a visual manner, even if you don't have a programming background. Instead of writing oodles of code, you visually design the way the application should look, and behave.

App Inventor is a Google Labs service, which is in beta testing. To get access to App Inventor, you need to visit http://goo.gl/Hsok and fill out the form. App Inventor users need to have Google accounts; the login authentication, and storage for your projects, is linked to your Google account. Google is rolling out access to the App Inventor system gradually, and you will receive a welcome email when you have been granted access. This email contains a link to the App Inventor site, and links to the documentation you need to get your PC and phone set up. It took around a month, if I remember right, for my request to be approved. However, in the past, with other products, Google has reduced the waiting period, and increased the number of accounts with access—so you may have to wait only for a short time.

Usage overview

The AIA Web application interface provides a palette of available components, a viewer/design canvas to which you drag components you want to use, a tree-view of added components, and a properties pane where you can configure the properties of the selected component.

While you design the user interface of your Android app in the AIA Web application, open a separate Java Web Start application called the Blocks Editor, in which you use automatically-defined blocks (and more) to set up the application's behaviour. The AIA Web application in the browser communicates with the Java application over the *localhost* interface (the Java application listening on a particular port, and the browser-based design application connecting to it). If you use Firefox, as I do, you can see the constant status-bar flickers as the browser communicates with '127.0.0.1'. The reason for the Blocks Editor being a separate Java application is so that it is outside the browser sand-box, and can communicate with the attached Android phone without being blocked (it uses the Android debugger, *adb*, which is among the tools that will be installed on the PC).

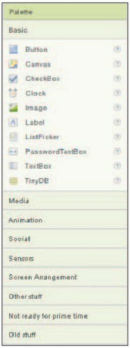

Figure 2: Components palette

The Blocks Editor, connected to an Android phone, displays a running version of the application you are designing and building. As you complete each block in the Blocks Editor, and it is parsed and found to be valid, the newly-created behaviour is exhibited by the application

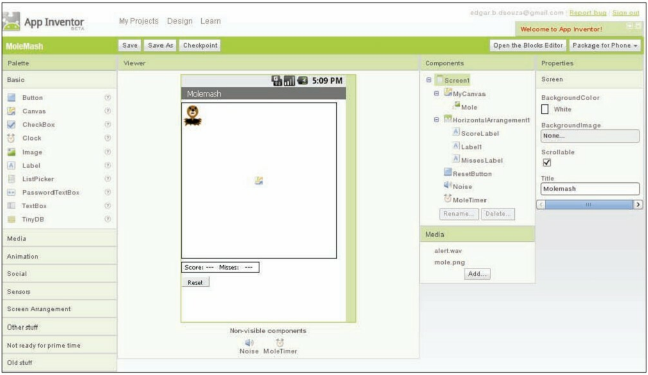

Figure 1: The AIA Web application